

Sweaty Soccer Stars: Why the 2026 World Cup Might Be the Hottest Ever

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Have you ever run around on a **scorching** day and felt like you were melting? Now imagine doing that in front of millions of fans at the World Cup! That's what soccer players might face in 2026. Scientists say this could be the hottest World Cup ever, with about one in four games played in very hot **conditions**. Last week, photos showed European players, who aren't used to such heat, lying on the field and pouring water over themselves to cool off. Norway's team even wore **ice collars** around their necks during a game! But England's captain, Harry Kane, says the heat won't be a problem because his team is training hard. So, what's really going on? **Climate** experts say the world is getting warmer, and many World Cup stadiums are in places like Dallas, Houston, and Miami, where summer days often hit 28°C (about 82°F). Some stadiums have **air conditioning**, but not all. The heat can make players sweat so much that they get tired, **cramp** up, or even feel dizzy. But coaches say good training can help. In fact, some teams from hot countries might even have a tiny advantage! So, will the heat be a game-changer? We'll have to watch and see just maybe with an ice-cold drink in hand.

Word Treasure

scorching -- Extremely hot, like when it's so hot you feel like you're burning.

conditions -- The state of the weather or environment, like if it's rainy or sunny.

ice collars -- Special collars filled with ice that you wear around your neck to cool down quickly.

climate -- The usual weather patterns of a place over a long time.

air conditioning -- A system that cools the air inside buildings or stadiums.

cramp -- When a muscle suddenly tightens and hurts, often from being tired or too hot.

Background you need

The World Cup is the biggest soccer tournament, held every four years in different countries. In 2022, Qatar hosted the World Cup, and many stadiums were air-conditioned because of the heat.

Harry Kane (England's team captain) has played in many hot games and thinks training helps.

Break it down

WHO: Soccer players, Harry Kane, and scientists

WHAT: The 2026 World Cup faces extreme heat that could make players tired, cramp, and dizzy

WHERE: In World Cup stadiums in hot U.S. cities like Dallas, Houston, and Miami

WHY: The world is getting warmer and the tournament is in summer, so games may reach 28°C

Why it matters

If you play sports on hot days, you know how tough it is to keep your energy up--just like these top athletes!

Test what you remember

1. What did Norway's team wear to stay cool?
 - (A) Ice collars
 - (B) Cooling vests
 - (C) Water-soaked hats
 - (D) Fans
2. Where will many World Cup stadiums be?
 - (A) Cold cities
 - (B) Dallas, Houston, and Miami
 - (C) Only in Europe
 - (D) In air-conditioned domes
3. What did European players do to cool off?
 - (A) Jumped in a pool
 - (B) Went inside
 - (C) Lying on field and pouring water over themselves
 - (D) Wore hats
4. What temperature do summer days often hit in those cities?
 - (A) 20°C
 - (B) 28°C
 - (C) 35°C
 - (D) 22°C
5. Who says the heat won't be a problem?
 - (A) The coach of Norway
 - (B) Harry Kane
 - (C) The scientists
 - (D) Yolanda Fierro
6. What fraction of games might be played in very hot conditions?
 - (A) Half
 - (B) All games
 - (C) One in four
 - (D) None

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: C 4: B 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **Hot-weather teams:** Players from places that are always hot might find the heat normal and could play better than teams from cooler countries.
2. **Heat safety concerns:** Some people worry that playing in very hot weather could be dangerous for players, leading to cramps or dizziness, which isn't fair.
3. **Climate reality:** Scientists point out that this is a sign of global warming, meaning future World Cups may need to adapt with air conditioning or different timing.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):